

Tread Together: Interactive Narrative Gameplay to Introspect and Scrutinise Privilege

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ABSTRACT

While ostensibly meritocratic, our society functions on an imperceptible yet undeniable paradigm of privilege. Privilege is an unearned, unasked for advantage gained because of the way society views an aspect of an individual's identity, such as race, caste, ethnicity, gender, socioeconomic status, and language. Privilege permeates nearly every facet of human existence and yet we seem to barely recognise its role in what are seemingly impartial outcomes. Tread Together is an interactive narrative based game that uses gameplay as a tool to help people better reflect on their own privilege and examine how it affects the people around them using a combination of critical and reflective design. The narrative transports players to embark on a journey through an alternative perspective in the game with the express intent of introspective contemplation and scrutiny of privilege as a dominant paradigm in society.

CCS CONCEPTS

• **Human-centered computing** → Human computer interaction (HCI); • **Applied computing** → Law, social and behavioral sciences; Sociology; • **Social and professional topics** → User characteristics.

KEYWORDS

Privilege, Gameplay, Interactive Narrative

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1 INTRODUCTION

Privilege, lucidly put, is societally granted, unearned advantage accorded to some people over others. Privilege is inextricably linked to oppression, because, while systems, social norms, and biases are advantages for some people, there are others who are disadvantaged by those same systems, norms, and biases. [6] Although privilege and oppression greatly impact how we all navigate and experience the world, for many of us being made aware of one's classification as linked to privilege is likely to remain a difficult topic to broach,

both personally and collectively. Indeed, many people have never been asked or required to reflect on their own privileged status, and doing so might feel uncomfortable or even discordant. Acknowledging privilege is further troubled by the fact that, more often than not, privilege attaches itself to norms, and thus becomes invisible through its normalisation. This has the effect of making many well-intentioned people view privilege as the goalpost instead of as a core aspect of how oppressive systems and structures operate to benefit some and inhibit others. [6] The disconnect in identity and experience of individuals is deeply intertwined in our most difficult challenges of poverty, disenfranchisement, isolation, inequity, and violence.

How might we help provoke people to scrutinise privilege in society? Is there a way to allow people to suspend their apprehensions in discovering their own privilege status? This paper introduces "Tread Together", an interactive narrative game that emboldens players to reflect and initiate conversations around privilege. Tread Together derives from the exercise of a "privilege walk" and addresses its deficiencies and concerns while leveraging the medium of serious games and narrative gameplay.

1.1 Provocation

Pursuant to the Covid-19 global pandemic, a nationwide lockdown was implemented in India that prompted the mandatory closure of factories and workplaces. India has an estimated 139 million migrant workers [2] that are often denied adequate healthcare, nutrition, housing and sanitation. With transportation systems initially shut down, loss of income, food shortages and uncertainty about their future, thousands of migrants began walking back with no recourse to travel options resulting in harrowing journeys back home. The shocking images of migrants forced to walk in desperation showed the enormity of the crisis.

Subsequently in the same interim, in a conversation about the then ongoing lockdown, a friend expressed their displeasure at the inability to go to the gym for their daily cardio on the treadmill. This dichotomy in society fuelled by privilege was an indication of how oblivious we can be to our own privilege and how that might affect others around us. This identification prompted the conception of Tread Together.

1.2 Background

Several attempts have been made in the past to make the process acknowledging, critiquing, and accepting privilege a more comfortable and visceral one. Most of these efforts are contingent on sharing of personal encounters and proximity to privilege. Privilege walks are often used as a tool to identify how individuals accrue privilege or acknowledge the lack thereof. [9] Other work/activities/exercises assume similar intent in recognition of privilege through different

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modalities. [12, 13] Activities like Privilege-For-Sale allow for a larger understanding that privilege is not only a legal construct but also social, religious and economical one. [10]. There have also been efforts in leveraging gamification to forward the aforementioned outcomes (for e.g. Reality Check). [7, 8]

2 RESEARCH

The research was carried out in two broad classifications: Primary Research and Secondary Research. For the latter, a comprehensive Literature Review was carried out to investigate and understand the nature of privilege [1, 3] and concatenated ideas around power, where power structures operate, their different forms and how they are constructed and survive. [4] Additional strands of inquiry led to insights around paucity in acknowledgment of societal and economic disparities (Wage Gap, existence of level playing field at work, investments etc.) [5]

The primary research involved 14 participants with ages ranging 22-30 years with 8 female and 6 male participants. These participants belonged to diverse demographics and different socio-cultural backgrounds. The main objectives of the primary research was as follows:

- (1) To identify people's perception around the concept of privilege.
- (2) To observe if people introspect and acknowledge their own privilege.
- (3) To ascertain the barriers in the communication and discussion of privilege.

To fulfil aforementioned objectives, following research methodologies were employed:

Focus Group Discussion: The discussions were conducted in two-groups with 5 members each. Discussions largely revolved around the existence of privilege and the extent of its permeation in the lived experience of individuals. The different kinds of benefits one may accrue by virtue of their privileged status and several mitigating factors in society.

Privilege Walk: In this exercise, several statements are read by a facilitator and the participants are asked to take a step forward or backward based on their responses. This activity forces participants to confront the ways in which society privileges some individuals over others and is designed to get participants to reflect on the different areas in their lives where they have privilege as well as the areas where they don't. An online version of this exercise was appropriated using Google Docs.

Semi-Structured Interview: Following the Privilege walk activity, participants were asked to partake in a semi-structured interview. Participants were asked to elucidate their experience from the previous activity and the emotions that the aforementioned exercise evoked. The data collected was qualitatively analysed.

Associative Experiment: This method was used to identify people's reception and experience of systemic privilege. Participants were asked to respond to different generative scenarios where privilege was at play, for e.g.: being passed over for an employment position based on their gender, ethnicity, age or sexual orientation etc. They were also encouraged to share anecdotal experiences where they benefited or were impeded by privilege.

Significance of privilege in accomplishments

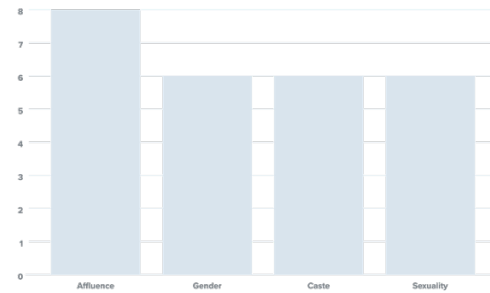


Figure 1: Does 'x' privilege significantly contribute to accomplishment? (Focus group discussion results)

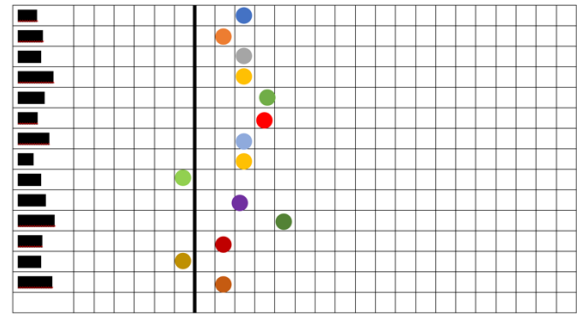


Figure 2: Outcomes from the online privilege walk exercise.

2.1 Research Insights

Of the 14 individuals that participated in the research, 9 responded with an affirmation that privilege plays an important role in personal success. This number increased to 12 respondents post the privilege walk exercise.

Focus Group Discussions predominantly concerned themselves with the extent to which people's privilege favours their accomplishment. Most participants (80%) agreed that financial affluence played a huge role in determining people's future success. Fewer (60%) concurred that gender and sexuality affected a person's achievements in a significant way. Only 6 of the 10 respondents believed that caste had a significant impact on people's accomplishments.

Nearly 85% of all participants responded positively to the Privilege walk exercise. There was collective consensus that the activity allowed participants to reflect and recognise their own privilege, a standpoint they disclosed was seldom expected of them to assume. In the semi-structured interviews following the exercise, multiple participants indicated their reluctance in accepting their privilege and consequently lack thereof. In the case of former, some participants indicated that recognition of privilege made them feel like they were invalidating their hard work whereas in the case of latter, participants felt a general discomfort in sharing certain intimate experiences with others. Given these experiences it was observed that privilege walks rely on people with marginalised

experiences to create recognition/understanding in the privileged participants of the exercise. Often these moments of sharing can be shame riddled and can possibly create a divide among participating individuals.

Associative experiment revealed that people responded to different generative scenarios with their own personal experiences in mind. Several people resonated with these generative scenarios which led to anecdotal responses. This allowed us to look at privilege through a more personal and substantive lens.

3 GAMEPLAY

Tread Together is an interactive narrative that uses walking as the primary mode of interaction. Players must walk or sprint on a treadmill so as to progress within the game. In addition to walking, players also use two buttons that allow them to navigate various choices, and in turn unfold divergent outcomes.



Figure 3: Player interacting with the game.

- (1) The game begins with the express intent of allowing players to identify their own privilege. Multiple statements are displayed on the screen. Players must either press a blue or red button to indicate agreement or disagreement with those statements respectively. Responses to these statements provide data toward self-evaluation of privilege status.
- (2) Following this, players are introduced to a context. It is indicated that the players must assume new identities within the game, as a proverbial "rebirth" to a lower privilege status and must now make decisions given this pre-condition.
- (3) Players walk through the game-world and are informed of key events/occurrences within the game. Eventually, the game leads the player to a critical circumstance, where they must make a choice. Decisions made toward these circumstances unfolds different conflicts and determines how the narrative unfolds going forward.
- (4) With the different choices that a player makes, certain affordances are also presented to them. Much like real-life, players can choose to supersede their hindrances in the game by augmenting their capabilities by sprinting at higher speeds.
- (5) The gameplay may end in one of two ways, (i) When the player reaches the final destination/end of their narrative or (ii) where the user stops the game due to exhaustion. For the former, players are shown the time they have taken to reach the end followed by the time they would have taken had

they played the game as themselves, with the current privilege they possess in real life. In case of the latter, players are shown their current position in the game (e.g. unemployed, lack of access to healthcare etc.) and the position they would have achieved had they been afforded the privilege they possess, in addition to the time disparity between their assumed character vs their real identity, owing to privilege.

4 DESIGN AND INTERACTION

Multiple instances within the research (both primary and secondary) indicated an inadequacy in the presence of situations or circumstances when individuals are compelled to question their own privilege, especially when their proximity to privilege is more. Although Privilege is complex and multi-layered, and often interacts with other aspects of identity, people's resistance to discuss/evaluate or communicate around the issue is the primary challenge. It was essential therefore to design a provocation that would provide an impetus to the aforementioned end.

Design Specification: The fundamental specifications of the solution were grounded in interactivity, empathy, experience and simplicity. On evaluating several mediums for staging the provocation, gameplay was chosen as the medium given its innate ability to generate empathy for its characters. [15]

Treadmill(s) and Walking: Taking from the central motivation (migrant crisis in India during the nationwide lockdown) outlined in this paper, the game uses walking as the principal interaction with the game. This interaction is afforded by the use of a treadmill, an object of privilege as elucidated by the provocation that prompted this game.

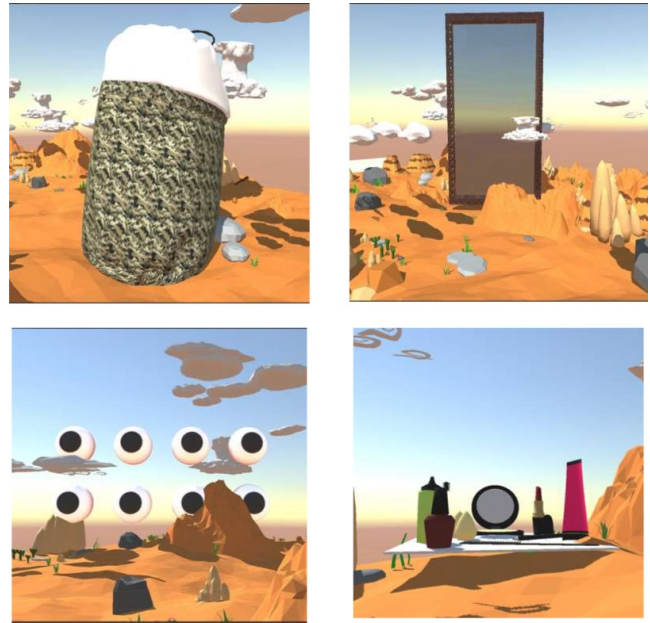


Figure 4: Referential objects from personal anecdotes around privilege in the game-world

Walking also allows for more embodied interactions that facilitate richer, more engaging experiences over decontextualized interactions via screens. In the game, walking is employed as a means to progressively unfold the narrative. Players are also presented with several opportunities to sprint, an affordance to overcome certain inhibiting factors within the gameplay. This modality of interaction embodies the hard-work or the ancillary effort as experienced by the character in the game experientially.

Buttons: Two buttons are used to navigate critical circumstances/junctures in the narratives. The buttons have complementary colours so as to avoid any confusion and derive from their semiotic meanings. It was imperative that navigation through the narrative was simple and uncomplicated to avoid generation of greater cognitive load as increased cognitive load may impact the empathy generated in human participants. [16] As a result all interventional choices made by the player are restricted to two buttons.

Game World: Following from the Associative Experiments, a number of anecdotes were collected from participants that illustrated their experiences with privilege. When building a world the game inhabits, objects pivotal to these stories were used. These objects were placed along the path of the player as a menagerie or museum of referential objects that reveal personal affects of privilege. These layered meanings in the gameplay are deeply rooted in the contextual and personal inquiry surrounding privilege.

5 PROTOTYPING

Given the circumstances around the pandemic, and in the absence of access to university campus or its resources, it was essential to identify key components to evaluate the validity of the concept and its implementation. With these limitations at play three prototypes were developed. The first prototype was an interactive questionnaire implemented as a progressive JavaScript web app. Users were expected to answer different questions that were indicative of a certain privilege, much like the beginning of the final game. The responses were recorded and a corresponding value was computed based on the respondents choices. Feedback was collected at the end.

To test the technical feasibility of integrating gameplay with treadmill controls, a prototype to control the speed of a treadmill using pulse width modulation was realised. However, in the absence of access to a treadmill, further testing would be prudent. Finally to actualize the game in a visual form, level design was carried out using Unity.

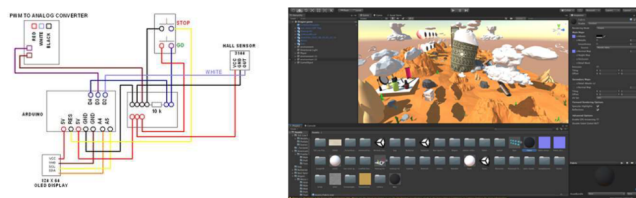


Figure 5: Prototypes: Circuit Diagram to control treadmill speeds using Arduino; Game Design prototype using Unity (L-R)

6 DISCUSSION

Tread Together aims at facilitating the acceptance and critique of privilege in society. The paper explores the modality of a provocation to initiate conversations and alleviate stigma around the concept. It must be noted however, that privilege is highly intersectional. Intersectionality refers to the ways aspects of identity intersect to create specific experiences, needs, privileges, and oppressions. [3] There is scope in the gameplay to accommodate for the nuances in the ways privilege may manifest in different circumstances and different identities.

Furthermore, as the world collectively dealt with the Covid-19 pandemic, Students across the nation were asked to urgently vacate campuses. Mumbai (current city of residence) quickly turned into an epicentre for the pandemic, and the entire nation was subjected to a lockdown. This severely limited the scope of prototyping. While some elementary levels of prototyping were achieved, a more well-rounded prototype for the game could not be realised as most resources (e.g. treadmills) remained inaccessible. It is unclear if the gameplay can accommodate for very complex storylines given the limitation of time that a player may be able to walk/sprint to interact with the game. For future scope, the game is being developed through robust implementation using integrated controls with a treadmill. The gameplay could also benefit from additional functionality in the form of different game modes to better understand different kinds and manifestations of privilege.

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